

They're driving me mad, my mom and dad...

38% because they force me to get up early every morning.

38% because they scold me when I lose or misplace things.

35% because they make me do too many things. I have no time to play.

31% because they constantly remind me to study.

29% because they expect me to get top grades in exams.

Source: Stress In Children, a study by Dr M. Mehta, AIIMS-ICMR, on 2,000 children aged between 8-14 years in 2003.

WHY YOUR KID IS DRIVING YOU CRAZY

Emotional outbursts, reckless risk-taking and rule-breaking occur in children because their brains lack the facilities for mature, responsible behaviour, shows a new research

Prefrontal Cortex The CEO of the brain, also called the area of sober second thought, is the last part of the brain to mature—which may be why teens get into trouble.

Corpus Callosum A bundle of nerve fibres involved in problem solving and creativity. Slow maturation in children lead to emotional imbalance.

Basal Ganglia Matures over the years. It acts like a secretary to the prefrontal cortex by helping it prioritise information.

Amygdala A developing Amygdala leads teens to react explosively to situations. This is the emotional centre of the brain, home to feelings like fear and rage.



Nowadays, even parents tend to overreact." Princess Franklyn, head of Bangalore's Bishop Cotton Girls High School agrees, "Every parent wants his/her ward to be a topper. Children soon pick up that competitive spirit, mostly in a negative sense." A Mumbai-based school teacher got a call from a parent questioning the C grade her child was awarded for an assignment. "The mother argued every point in the essay," she recalls, "I soon realised why she was so upset. She had written it." Another teacher in Delhi told a girl in her class that she needed to step up her homework. "Her mom came in the next day," the teacher says, "and started yelling at me, alleging that I had emotionally upset her child."

The shifting contours of the post-globalisation family have created new circumstances of parenting. "Urban homes are primarily nuclear, offering greater freedom to parents to develop their own ideals and patterns of parenting," says Delhi-based counsellor Gitanjali Kumar. With more working mothers and greater participation of fathers in child-care, parent-child relationship

has changed. "At the end of a long workweek, it's tempting to buy peace with a 'yes', rather than mar precious family time with conflict," says Kalpana Kapoor, chief learning officer of Delhi Public School (DPS), Vasundhara, Ghaziabad. "Children often call the shots these days," she adds.

What parents need to find, psychologists say, is a balance between the advantages of an affluent society and the critical life lessons that come from saving and working hard to achieve goals. Sriparna Basu, a consultant with a clutch of business schools in Delhi, loves to treat her son, Sumantra, 4, to clothes and toys. But she and her husband are trying hard to be reasonable and not spend too much on a child who still hasn't learnt to write. "We don't want to give in to his every whim. We would like to run the show," says Basu. That's more easily said than done. Consider Himanshu and Raka Chakrawarti of Chennai. With their heavy corporate schedules, they often end up submitting to their three-year-old daughter, Anaya's, sometimes, unjustified demands. "She knows how to get us to say yes," says Raka. Anaya's birthday